100 years earlier, had embarked on such study missions, the most prominent among them being the Iwakura embassy, which toured several European countries during 1871–73. It comprised fifty high officials, scholars and engineers and fifty students in different disciplines. The extensive reports submitted by both the Japanese and Chinese missions, separated as they were by 100 years, played a key role in convincing political elites in both countries that they needed to undertake urgent and far-reaching reforms if they were to avoid falling irretrievably behind the West.

Deng Xiaoping himself paid highly publicized visits to the US, Japan and Western Europe in 1978–79 and to the more successful South-East Asian countries like Singapore. Lee Kuan Yew, the architect of Singapore's remarkable economic success, was a valued adviser, helped by the perception that he was running a one-party and authoritarian state, like China itself. Television coverage of Deng's visits to advanced centres of scientific research, modern production facilities and services such as Japan's bullet train, served the purpose of making Chinese leaders and people aware of how much they had fallen behind, and helped overcome opposition to economic reforms, particularly from more ideologically inclined party cadres. It helped, too, that the Western countries, led by the US, regarded China as an ally against the Soviet Union in the still-raging East–West Cold War. Geopolitics eased Chinese access to what the West had to offer in terms of both higher education and technology.

Over the next four decades, while building its knowledge and human resources, China followed its own step-by-step development pathway. It absorbed the advanced technologies of the West and Japan like a giant sponge, but used these systematically to steadily build up its own capabilities. This phase of assimilation has enabled China to emerge as a knowledge generator in its own right. It may even be ahead of its former teachers like the US and Japan in a whole range of cutting-edge technologies such as artificial intelligence and quantum computing and in wireless technologies like 5G and robotics.

In agriculture, China dismantled the communes, and peasants were